12

Léa

That same night, Léa sat in the back of the police van, gripping the sides as it rocked over the uneven road. She'd thought they'd take her to the detention center in the mairie or the police station in Orléans, but they'd been driving too long for that. She couldn't imagine where she was going. She hoped that Rose had made it through the tunnel without being caught. Despite everything, she'd managed to keep her sister safe.

The back doors swung open the moment the van came to a stop. In the murky light, an arm reached inside and grabbed Léa, yanking her out. She stumbled as her feet hit the ground, landing on her knee. A sharp, searing pain shot up her leg. She pushed herself up, blinking back tears.

"Go to the gate," the gendarme shouted, pointing ahead. He'd left the engine running. The acrid fumes scratched her throat. Beams of light shone down from towering wooden poles, revealing the gate, wide enough for a car to pass, with military guards in front. To the side, barbed wire extended in all directions.

Léa limped toward the gate, trying to shift the weight off her injured knee. A guard pulled back the barrier, gesturing for her to pass through. Someone knocked on the door of a building next to the gate. It opened, and she went inside.

After crossing the threshold, she looked down at her knee. The skin was raw and pink. Blood trickled down her shin. One gendarme stood behind a desk, took her paper and read it.

"It's the middle of the night." He looked down at a book on the table, then eyed Léa. "You'll have to share a bunk in cabin F for tonight." He pointed to a door. "Through there."